



Captive guerrillas

Suspected Viet Cong fighters await interrogation by the US Marines in July 1967. They had been rounded up near the DMZ. US forces did not hold prisoners long term, but took advantage of their capture to question them for information about enemy plans.

Raid on Son Tay

In tandem with diplomatic efforts to obtain the release of US prisoners, the Nixon administration wanted a military success in Vietnam to demonstrate to the North and the American public that the US political will to fight the war remained strong. In June, military intelligence had reported 50 American POWs at a camp at Son Tay about 23 miles (37 km) north of Hanoi. This seemed to provide the opportunity to liberate American prisoners from the heart of North Vietnam, which would be a valuable propaganda coup.

On the night of November 20, 1970, US Air Force helicopters ferried 56 US Army Rangers into Son Tay. What the intelligence had failed to discover was that, due to flooding from heavy July rains, the North Vietnamese authorities had moved the prisoners about 15 miles (24 km) away. There were no prisoners to be rescued at Son Tay. No American lives were lost in the raid, which was considered a tactical success and could well have rescued prisoners had they still been there. Press reaction was mixed. Some commentators saw it as a courageous attempt worth the risk, though others labeled it a foolhardy and provocative act. While Nixon did not get the kind of accolades he wanted, the action did impress the North Vietnamese. The United States had inserted and extracted troops very near to their capital and had inflicted a significant number of casualties on the camp's defenders. Following this incident, the North Vietnamese closed the scattered prison camps and consolidated all POWs in Hanoi. Living conditions became very crowded in the Hanoi Hilton, with some men sleeping shoulder to shoulder, but the increased contact had the benefit of enhancing prisoner morale.